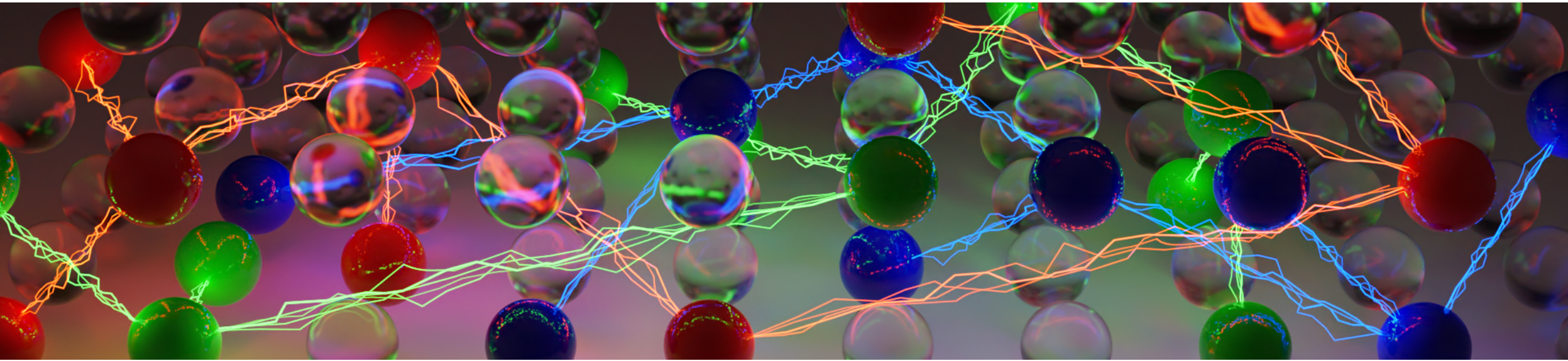
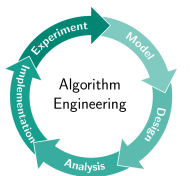




Practical SAT Solving

Lecture 1 – Organization, Introduction, Incremental SAT Solving

Markus Iser, Dominik Schreiber | April 22, 2025



SAtRes
Scalable Automated Reasoning

Organisation

- 14 Lectures: Mondays at 3:45 pm, room 301
- 7 Exercises: Tuesdays at 3:45 pm, room 301 (starting May 6, every other week)
- Bring your laptop if you can!
- Sign up:
 - <http://campus.studium.kit.edu>
- Find material (lecture plan, slides, exercises, code) on our course website:
 - <https://satlecture.github.io/kit2025/>

Organisers

- Lecturer: **Dr. Markus Iser**

Contact: markus.iser@kit.edu

Expert in Boolean Reasoning and Empirical Algorithmics

Involved in this lecture since 2020 (guest lectures before then)

– Post-doc at Algorithm Engineering group

- Lecturer: **Dr. Dominik Schreiber**

Contact: dominik.schreiber@kit.edu

Expert in parallel and distributed SAT solving

Involved in this lecture since 2023 (guest lectures before then)

– Scalable Automated Reasoning (SatRes) group leader

- Co-manager of exercises: **Niccolò Rigi-Luperti**

Contact: niccolo.rigi-luperti@kit.edu

– Doctoral researcher @ SAtRes group

- Previous Lecturers: Prof. Carsten Sinz, Dr. Tomáš Balyo

– Founders of the Practical SAT Solving Lecture at KIT in 2015

Homework, Competitions, and Oral Exam

- You earn exercise points for doing homework and coming to class with your solutions.
 - For each exercise, the lucky “referee” is chosen randomly among all who stated that they prepared it
 - No need to prepare a highly polished artifact! You need a **clear idea and approach** (+ **code** for practical exercises).
 - Not being able to present an exercise after stating to be able **invalidates all earned points so far**
- You can earn **at least 120 exercise points** during the semester (+ more bonus points).
 - Some exercises will be in the form of small implementation contests.
 - Contest winners will receive bonus points.
 - We encourage group work! Jointly winning a contest gets each participant an equal share of the bonus points.
- You must earn **at least 60 points** to participate in the oral exam.
- Earning **at least 120 points** will improve the grade of your **passed oral exam** by one step.

Goals of this Lecture

Efficient Methods for SAT Solving

Algorithms, Heuristics, Data Structures, Implementation Techniques, Parallelism, Proof Systems, ...

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General Encoding Techniques, CNF Encodings of Constraints, Properties of CNF Encodings, ...

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Practical Hardness of SAT

Tractable Classes, Instance Structure, Hardest Instances, Proof Complexity, ...

Basic Definitions

In this lecture, propositional formulas are given in *conjunctive normal form* (CNF), and if not, we convert them.

CNF Formulas

- A *CNF formula* is a conjunction (and = $\wedge$) of clauses.
- A *clause* is a disjunction (or = $\vee$) of literals.
- A *literal* is a Boolean variable x (positive literal) or its negation $\bar{x}$ (negative literal).

Example (CNF Formula)

$$\begin{aligned} F &= (\bar{x}_1 \vee x_2) \wedge (\bar{x}_1 \vee \bar{x}_2 \vee x_3) \wedge (x_1) \\ \text{vars}(F) &= \{x_1, x_2, x_3\} \\ \text{lits}(F) &= \{x_1, \bar{x}_1, x_2, \bar{x}_2, x_3\} \\ \text{clss}(F) &= \{\{\bar{x}_1, x_2\}, \{\bar{x}_1, \bar{x}_2, x_3\}, \{x_1\}\} \end{aligned}$$

Typically, a CNF formula is given as a set of clauses, where each clause is a set of literals (as in $\text{clss}(F)$).

Satisfiability

The *Satisfiability Problem* is to determine whether a given formula is satisfiable.

A CNF formula F is *satisfiable* iff there exists an assignment to $\text{vars}(F)$ that satisfies F .

Satisfying Assignment

Given a CNF formula F over variables $V := \text{vars}(F)$, a *truth assignment* $\phi : V \rightarrow \{\top, \perp\}$ assigns a truth value $\top$ (True) or $\perp$ (False) to each Boolean variable in V .

We say that ϕ satisfies

- a CNF formula if it satisfies all of its clauses
- a clause if it satisfies at least one of its literals
- a positive literal x if $\phi(x) = \top$
- a negative literal $\bar{x}$ if $\phi(x) = \perp$

Satisfiability

Example (Satisfiable or Unsatisfiable?)

$$F_1 = \{\{x_1\}\}$$

$$F_2 = \{\{x_1\}, \{\overline{x_1}\}\}$$

$$F_3 = \{\{x_2, x_3, \overline{x_3}\}\}$$

$$F_4 = \{\{x_1\}, \{\overline{x_2}\}, \{x_2, \overline{x_1}\}\}$$

$$F_5 = \{\{x_1, x_2\}, \{\overline{x_1}, x_2\}, \{x_1, \overline{x_2}\}, \{\overline{x_1}, \overline{x_2}\}\}$$

$$F_6 = \{\{\overline{x_1}, x_2\}, \{\overline{x_1}, \overline{x_2}, x_3\}, \{x_1\}\}$$

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Edge Cases:

What are the shortest satisfiable / unsatisfiable CNF formulas?

Satisfiability

Example (Scheduling)

Schedule a meeting of Adam, Bridget, Charles, and Darren considering the following constraints

- Adam can only meet on Monday or Wednesday
- Bridget cannot meet on Wednesday
- Charles cannot meet on Friday
- Darren can only meet on Thursday or Friday

$$\text{vars}(F) = \{x_1, x_2, x_3, x_4, x_5\}$$

$$F =$$

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$$F = (x_1 \vee x_3) \wedge (\overline{x_3}) \wedge (\overline{x_5}) \wedge (x_4 \vee x_5) \\ \wedge \text{AtMostOne}(x_1, x_2, x_3, x_4, x_5)$$

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Is this Scheduling Instance Satisfiable?

Complexity of Propositional Satisfiability

A decision problem is NP-complete if it is in NP and every problem in NP can be reduced to it in polynomial time.

SAT is NP-complete (Cook-Levin Theorem)

- SAT is in NP
Proof: solution can be checked in polynomial time
- Every problem in NP can be reduced to SAT in polynomial time
Proof: encode the run of a non-deterministic Turing machine as a CNF formula

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Consequences of NP-completeness of SAT

- We do not have a polynomial algorithm for SAT (yet) 😊
- If $P \neq NP$ then we will never have a polynomial algorithm for SAT 😞
- All the known NP-complete algorithms have exponential runtime in the **worst case** 😡

Example (Hardness)

Try it yourself: <http://www.cs.utexas.edu/~marijn/game/>

History of Propositional Satisfiability

Historic Landmarks

- 1960: DP Algorithm (first SAT solving algorithm)
- 1962: DPLL Algorithm (improving upon DP algorithm)
- 1971: SAT is NP-Complete
- 1992: Local Search Algorithm Selman et al.: A New Method for Solving Hard Satisfiability Problems
- 1992: The First International SAT Competition (followed by 1993, 1996, since 2002 every year)
- 1996: The First International SAT Conference (Workshop) (followed by 1998, since 2000 every year)
- 1999: Conflict Driven Clause Learning (CDCL) Algorithm

Advancements

From 1992 to 2024, SAT solvers have improved by **several orders of magnitude** in terms of feasible problem size. From 100 variables and 200 clauses to 21,000,000 variables and 96,000,000 clauses.

SAT Conference



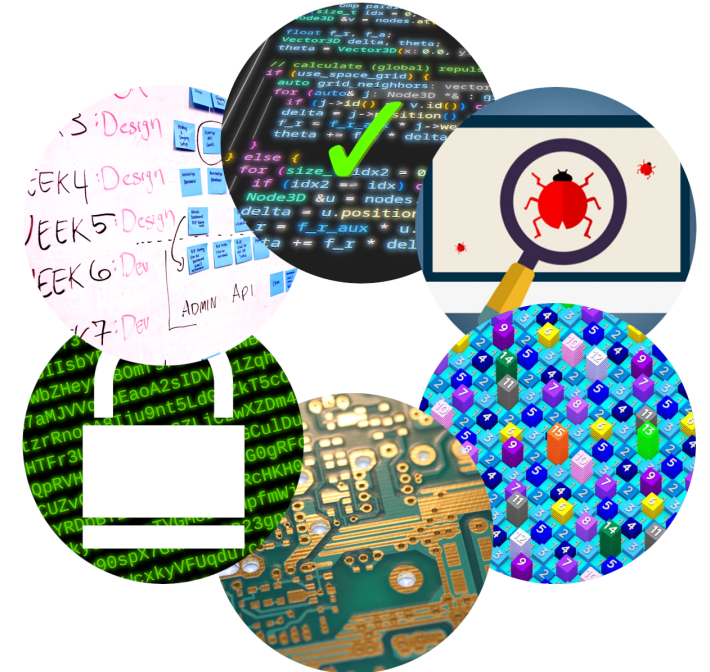
2022, Haifa, Israel



2024, Pune, India

Applications of SAT Solving

- Hardware verification and design
 - Major hardware companies (Intel, ...) use SAT to verify chip designs
 - Computer Aided Design of electronic circuits
- Software verification
 - SAT-based SMT solvers are used to verify Microsoft software products and Amazon Web Services' core software libraries
 - Embedded software in cars, airplanes, refrigerators, ...
 - Unix utilities
- Automated planning and scheduling in Artificial Intelligence
 - Job shop scheduling, train scheduling, multi-agent path finding
- Cryptanalysis
 - Test/prove properties of cryptographic ciphers, hash functions
- Number theoretic problems (Pythagorean triples, grid coloring)
- Solving other NP-hard problems (coloring, clique, ...)



SAT Solving in the News

SPIEGEL ONLINE DER SPIEGEL SPIEGEL TV  [Anmelden](#)

≡ WISSENSCHAFT

[Schlagzeilen](#) | [Wetter](#) | [DAX 12.060,78](#) | [TV-Programm](#) | [Abo](#)

[Nachrichten](#) > [Wissenschaft](#) > [Mensch](#) > [Mathematik](#) > Der längste Mathe-Beweis der Welt umfasst 200 Terabyte

Zahlenrätsel

Der längste Mathe-Beweis der Welt

Drei Mathematiker haben ein Zahlenrätsel geknackt - mithilfe eines Supercomputers. Der Beweis umfasst 200 Terabyte. Sie wollen wissen, worum es geht? Okay, versuchen wir es.



Von **Holger Dambeck** ✓



Supercomputer als Mathematiker

DPA

COMBINATORICS

The Number 15 Describes the Secret Limit of an Infinite Grid

 13 | 

The “packing coloring” problem asks how many numbers are needed to fill an infinite grid so that identical numbers never get too close to one another. A new computer-assisted proof finds a surprisingly straightforward answer.



Pythagorean Triples

Problem Definition

Is it possible to assign to each integer $1, 2, \dots, n$ one of two colors such that if $a^2 + b^2 = c^2$ then a, b and c do not all have the same color.

- Solution: Nope
- for $n = 7825$ it is not possible
- proof obtained by a SAT solver has 200 Terabytes – back then the largest Math proof yet

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How to encode this?

- for each integer i we have a Boolean variable x_i , $x_i = 1$ if color of i is 1, $x_i = 0$ otherwise.
- for each a, b, c such that $a^2 + b^2 = c^2$ we have two clauses: $(x_a \vee x_b \vee x_c)$ and $(\overline{x_a} \vee \overline{x_b} \vee \overline{x_c})$

Arithmetic Progressions

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- Writing, e.g., $\bar{2}\bar{5}\bar{8}$ for the clause $(\overline{x_2} \vee \overline{x_5} \vee \overline{x_8})$, we arrive at 32 clauses for the 9 digit sequence:
123, 234, $\dots$, 789, 135, 246, $\dots$, 579, 147, 258, 369, 159, $\bar{1}\bar{2}\bar{3}$, $\bar{2}\bar{3}\bar{4}$, $\dots$, $\bar{7}\bar{8}\bar{9}$, $\bar{1}\bar{3}\bar{5}$, $\bar{2}\bar{4}\bar{6}$, $\dots$, $\bar{5}\bar{7}\bar{9}$, $\bar{1}\bar{4}\bar{7}$, $\bar{2}\bar{5}\bar{8}$, $\bar{3}\bar{6}\bar{9}$, $\bar{1}\bar{5}\bar{9}$.

Background: Van der Waerden Numbers

Theorem (van der Waerden)

If n is sufficiently large, every sequence $x_1, \dots, x_n$ of numbers $0 \leq x_i < r$ contains a number that occurs at least k times equally spaced.

- The smallest such number is the van der Waerden number $W(r, k)$.
- For larger r, k the numbers are only partially known.

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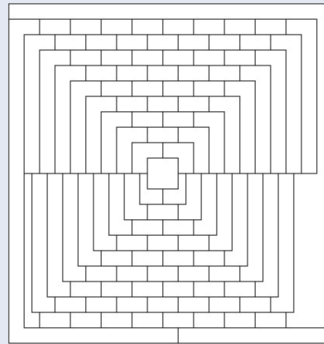
Example (Van der Waerden Numbers)

- We have seen that $W(2, 3) = 9$.
- $W(2, 6) = 1132$ was shown in [2008 by Kouril and Paul] (using a SAT solver!)
- but $W(2, 7)$ is yet unknown.
- $2^{2^{r2^{k+9}}}$ is an upper bound for $W(r, k)$ (shown in [2001 by Gowers]).

Graph Coloring

Example (McGregor Graph, 110 nodes, planar)

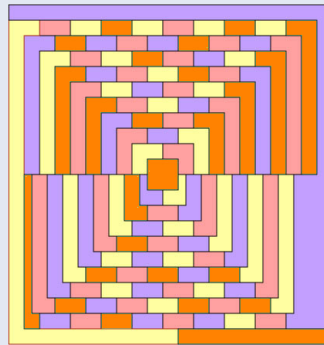
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Graph Coloring: SAT Encoding

Definition: Graph Coloring Problem (GCP)

Given an undirected graph $G = (V, E)$ and a number k , a k -coloring assigns one of k colors to each node, such that all adjacent nodes have a different color. The GCP asks whether a k -coloring for G exists.

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■ Variables:

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- Variables:

- use $k \cdot |V|$ Boolean variables v_j for $v \in V$, where v_j is true, if node v gets color j ($1 \leq j \leq k$).

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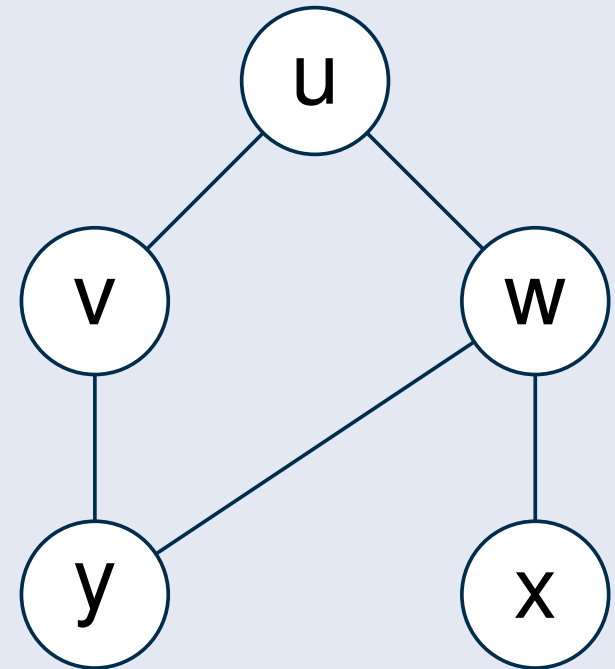
$$(\overline{u_j} \vee \overline{v_j}) \text{ for } u, v \in E, 1 \leq j \leq k$$

- Suppress multiple colors for a node: At-most-one constraints

Graph Coloring: Example

Example (Graph Coloring Problem)

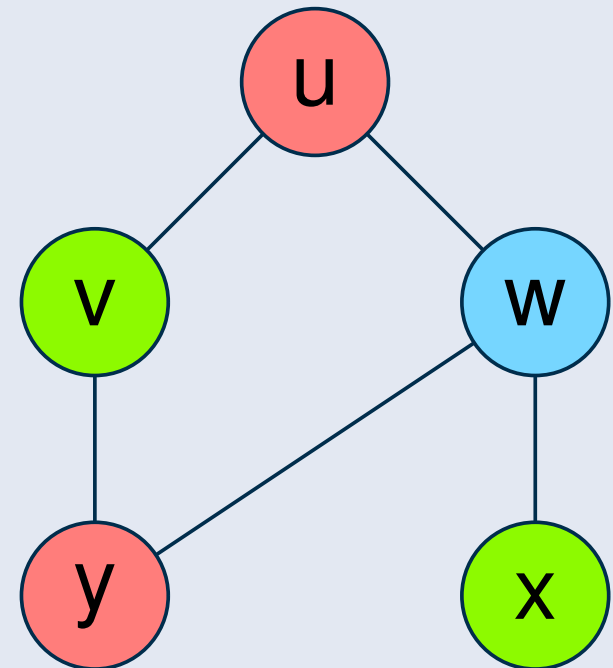
- $V = \{u, v, w, x, y\}$
- Colors: red (=1), green (=2), blue (=3)
- Clauses:
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 $\vdots$
 $(y_1 \vee y_2 \vee y_3)$
 - “adjacent nodes have different colors” $(\overline{u_1} \vee \overline{v_1}) \wedge \dots \wedge (\overline{u_3} \vee \overline{v_3})$
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Using a SAT Solver

SAT solvers are command line applications that take as argument a text file with a formula (DIMACS format).

Example (Input)

```
c comments, ignored by solver
p cnf 7 22
1 -2 7 0
...
-7 -3 -2 0
```

Using a SAT Solver

SAT solvers are command line applications that take as argument a text file with a formula (DIMACS format).

Example (Input)

```
c comments, ignored by solver
p cnf 7 22
1 -2 7 0
...
-7 -3 -2 0
```

Example (Output)

```
c comments, usually some statistics about the solving
s SATISFIABLE
v 1 2 -3 -4
v 5 -6 -7 0
```

Running a SAT Solver

Let's try it!

- Download and Build a SAT solver:
 - [CaDiCaL](#)
 - Alternatives: [Kissat](#), [Minisat](#), [CryptoMinisat](#), [Maplesat](#), ...
- Download a CNF formula:
 - [Global Benchmark Database](#)
- Run the SAT solver with the CNF formula as input

Incremental SAT Solving

In many applications, we solve a sequence of similar SAT instances:

Planning, Bounded Model Checking, SMT, Scheduling, MaxSAT, ...

Incremental SAT Solving

- The SAT solver is initialized once
- Each call to `solve()` takes a set of assumptions as input
→ assumptions are literals that serve as a partial assignment to their variables
- Like this also clauses can be activated/deactivated in the SAT solver
- Between `solve()` calls, new clauses can be added
- Advantages:

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- Between `solve()` calls, new clauses can be added
- Advantages:
 - solver remembers learned clauses, preprocessing, variable scores (heuristics), etc.
 - (de)initialization overheads removed

IPASIR: Incremental Library Interface for SAT Solvers

IPASIR = Re-entrant Incremental Satisfiability Application Program Interface (acronym reversed)

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- Defined for the 2015 SAT Race to unify incremental SAT solver interfaces
- IPASIR has become a standard interface of incremental SAT solving
- Version 2 is in the works



IPASIR Overview

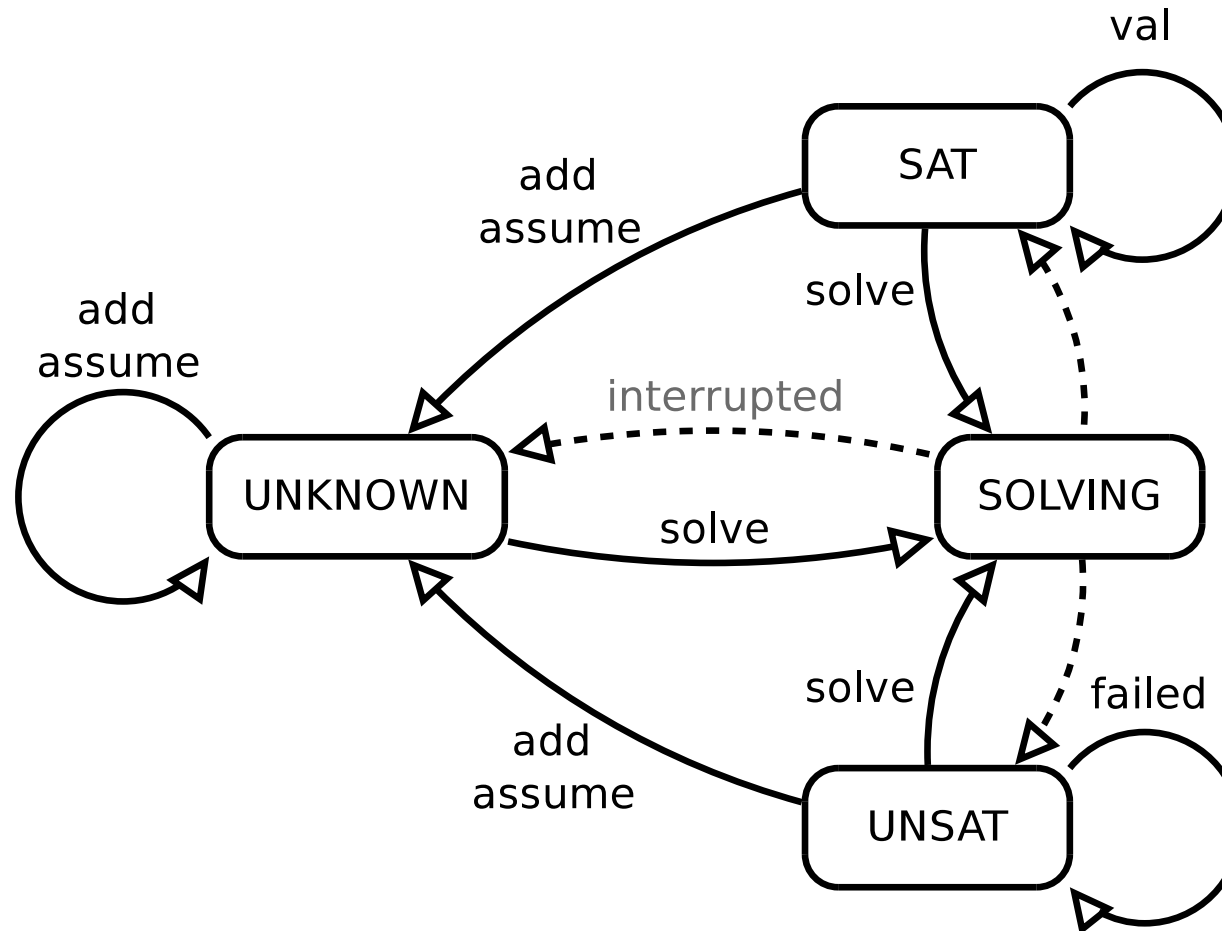
- Clauses are added one literal at a time
 - To add $(x_1 \vee \overline{x_4})$ call `add(1); add(-4); add(0);`
- You can call a SAT solver with a set of assumptions
 - Assumptions are basically temporary decision literals
 - Assumptions are cleared after each `solve()` call
- Clause removal is controlled with activation literals
 - You must know ahead which clauses you will maybe want to remove
 - Add the clause with an additional fresh variable (activation literal)
 - Example: instead of $(x_1 \vee x_2)$ add $(x_1 \vee x_2 \vee a_1)$
 - solve with with assumption $\overline{a_1}$ to enforce $(x_1 \vee x_2)$

IPASIR Functions

<code>signature</code>	return the name and version of the solver
<code>init</code>	initialize the solver, the pointer it returns is used for the rest of the functions
<code>add</code>	add clauses, one literal at a time
<code>assume</code>	add an assumption, the assumptions are cleared after a <code>solve()</code> call
<code>solve</code>	solve the formula, return SAT, UNSAT or INTERRUPTED
<code>val</code>	return the truth value of a variable (if SAT)
<code>failed</code>	returns true if the given assumption was part of reason for UNSAT

For more details and examples of usage see <https://github.com/biotomas/ipasir>

IPASIR Solver States



Use Case: Essential Variables

Let a satisfiable formula F be given.

Essential Variables

- Satisfying assignments can be partial, i.e., some variables are not assigned but still the formula is satisfied.
- A variable x is *essential* if and only if it has to be assigned (True or False) in each satisfying assignment.

Task: find all the essential variables of a given satisfiable formula

- use *Dual Rail Encoding* – for each variable x add two new variables x_P and x_N , replace each positive (negative) occurrence of x with x_P (x_N), add a clause $(\overline{x_P} \vee \overline{x_N})$ (meaning x cannot be both true and false).
- for each variable x solve the formula with the assumptions $\overline{x_P}$ and $\overline{x_N}$. If the formula is UNSAT then x is essential.

Let's implement it!